Speaking toolkit and exam phrases

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Speaking with confidence: phrases for the exam (242 words)

Fluency in an exam does not come from memorizing long answers; it comes from having a few flexible phrases and knowing when to use them. When you give an opinion, try **as far as I'm concerned** or **I'd say** followed by your view. If you need time, **let me think** is perfectly natural, and so is **to be honest** when you want to sound sincere. **In my experience**, a personal example is often the strongest way to support a point.

To show balance, use **on the one hand** and **on the other hand**, or admit that **it depends on** the situation. When you are only partly sure, **to some extent** or **not necessarily** keeps your answer honest. If you want to make a general statement, say **generally speaking**; to introduce an example, begin with **for instance**. When you wish to give a result, **that is why** links your reasons neatly, and **what I mean is** lets you clarify an idea you explained badly.

Good speakers also vary their vocabulary: **a wide range of** activities sounds better than a lot of activities, and a teacher can **play a key role** in a child's life. For a conclusion, **all things considered** and **in the long run** give your answer a polished finish. When something is obvious, **it goes without saying** works well, and even **I can't help but** can add personality. Practice these until they come **without thinking**, and your speaking will sound calm and confident.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
without thinking	automatically

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
as far as I'm concerned	phrase	in my opinion	*As far as I'm concerned, public transport should be free.*
to be honest	phrase	to say what I really think	*To be honest, I rarely use the bus.*
it depends on	phrase	used when there is no simple answer	*It depends on the person and the situation.*
on the one hand	phrase	used to introduce the first point	*On the one hand, cars are convenient.*
on the other hand	phrase	used to introduce the second point	*On the other hand, they cause pollution.*
in the long run	phrase	over a long period of time	*In the long run, recycling saves money.*

for instance	phrase	used to give an example	*For instance, a city can add cycle lanes.*
what I mean is	phrase	used to explain more clearly	*What I mean is that cost matters most.*
that is why	phrase	used to give a result	*That is why I prefer to study at home.*
I'd say	phrase	used before giving an opinion	*I'd say it is a mix of both.*
generally speaking	phrase	in most cases	*Generally speaking, young people prefer apps.*
not necessarily	phrase	not always true	*Expensive schools are not necessarily better.*
to some extent	phrase	partly	*To some extent, I agree with that.*
it goes without saying	phrase	it is obvious	*It goes without saying that health comes first.*
let me think	phrase	used to gain time to think	*Let me think, I would probably choose a quiet place.*
I can't help but	phrase	I cannot stop myself from	*I can't help but admire their courage.*
in my experience	phrase	from what I have seen myself	*In my experience, small groups work best.*
a wide range of	phrase	many different	*The shop sells a wide range of books.*
play a key role	phrase	be very important	*Teachers play a key role in motivation.*
all things considered	phrase	after thinking about everything	*All things considered, I would choose the city.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
economy	n	the system of money and trade in a country
inflation	n	a general rise in prices
recession	n	a period of weak economic activity
income	n	money received regularly
wealth	n	a large amount of money or property
gap between rich and poor	n	the difference in wealth
consumption	n	the use of goods and resources
budget	n	a plan for spending money
invest	v	to put money into something to make profit
debt	n	money you owe

Practice: fill the gaps

that is why · play a key role · I'd say · as far as I'm concerned · to be honest · what I mean is · on the other hand · on the one hand

1. _____ I prefer to study at home.
2. Teachers _____ in motivation.
3. _____ it is a mix of both.
4. _____, public transport should be free.
5. _____, I rarely use the bus.
6. _____ that cost matters most.
7. _____, they cause pollution.
8. _____, cars are convenient.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

absolutely (adv): completely
actually (adv): in fact
admittedly (adv): used to accept a point
basically (adv): in the main
frankly (adv): speaking honestly
honestly (adv): truthfully
mind you (phrase): used to add a different view
no doubt (phrase): certainly
now that you mention it (phrase): used when reminded
one thing is for sure (phrase): a point that is certain
personally (adv): in my own view
presumably (adv): probably
strictly speaking (phrase): in the exact sense
to put it another way (phrase): used to explain again
to tell you the truth (phrase): honestly
the thing is (phrase): used to introduce a key point
what's more (phrase): used to add a stronger point
as for (phrase): used to change the subject
as I see it (phrase): in my view
by the way (phrase): used to add a side point
in a nutshell (phrase): in few words
in other words (phrase): used to rephrase
needless to say (phrase): obviously
the main reason is (phrase): used to give a cause
that said (phrase): used to introduce a contrast
to be fair (phrase): used to give a balanced view
truth be told (phrase): honestly
up to a point (phrase): partly
with that in mind (phrase): considering that
you know what I mean (phrase): used to check understanding

Answers

1. That is why (that is why)
2. play a key role (play a key role)
3. I'd say (I'd say)
4. As far as I'm concerned (as far as I'm concerned)
5. To be honest (to be honest)
6. What I mean is (what I mean is)
7. On the other hand (on the other hand)
8. On the one hand (on the one hand)